



Australian Government
Department of Agriculture,
Fisheries and Forestry

SECRETARY

REF: EC26-000497

The Hon Julie Collins MP
Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry
Parliament House
CANBERRA ACT 2600

Dear Minister

Thank you for your letter of 22 December 2025, enclosing the Ministerial Statement of Expectations (SOE) for the Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry (the department).

I acknowledge the Government's clear expectations regarding the department's regulatory role and its accountability to Parliament, including through Senate Estimates and scrutiny by the Australian National Audit Office, as outlined in *Regulator Performance Resource Management Guide 128* (RMG 128).

I am pleased to provide, attached, the department's responding Statement of Intent (SOI), which sets out how the department will respond to and deliver on the expectations outlined in your SOE. The SOI outlines how the department will achieve its regulatory objectives and how it will perform its functions and exercise its powers in a manner consistent with your expectations.

The department will publish the SOI alongside your SOE on its website and integrate these statements into its performance and governance processes as required under the *Public Governance, Performance and Accountability Act 2013*.

Yours sincerely

Victoria Anderson

27 March 2026

Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry Statement of Intent

The Department of Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry (the department) is committed to supporting improvements in Australia's productivity performance as a priority for the Australian Government, through effective, proportionate and trusted regulation.

The department recognises the critical role that regulation and regulators play in managing risk, enabling innovation, supporting economic growth and maintaining public confidence, particularly in an increasingly complex and interconnected global environment. In delivering its regulatory responsibilities, the department will take a risk-based, proportionate approach that balances appropriate protections for Australians with efficiency, growth and dynamism across agricultural, fisheries and forestry industries (the agricultural sector).

This Statement of Intent (SOI) responds to the Minister for Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry's Statement of Expectations (SOE) issued on 22 December 2025. It outlines how the department will meet the government's expectations in relation to its regulatory functions, consistent with the *Regulator Performance Resource Management Guide 128* (RMG 128), the *Regulatory Policy, Practice and Performance Framework*, the Australian Public Service (APS) Reform Agenda, and the department's obligations under the *Public Governance, Performance and Accountability Act 2013* (PGPA Act).

The SOI sets out how the department will deliver its regulatory objectives, perform its functions and exercise its powers in line with the Minister's expectations.

Regulatory responsibilities

The department is responsible for delivering five of the eight regulatory functions in the Agriculture, Fisheries and Forestry portfolio, with the other three being delivered by the Australian Pesticides and Veterinary Medicines Authority, the Australian Fisheries Management Authority, and Wine Australia, each with their own SOIs.

This SOI applies to the following five regulatory functions:

- assessing and managing biosecurity risks and risks relating to ballast water as the Director of Biosecurity pursuant to the *Biosecurity Act 2015* and associated charging legislation
- regulating goods for export pursuant to the *Export Control Act 2020* and associated charging legislation
- prohibiting the importation of illegally logged timber and the processing of illegally logged domestic raw logs as regulator pursuant to the *Illegal Logging Prohibition Act 2012* and associated Rules
- ensuring food imported into Australia complies with Australian food standards and public health and safety requirements pursuant to the *Imported Food Control Act 1992* and associated charging legislation
- administering primary industry levy and charges collection and disbursement pursuant to the *Primary Industries Levies and Charge Collection Act 2024* and the *Primary Industry Levies and Charges Disbursement Act 2024* and associated imposition legislation.

The department will deliver these regulatory functions in the public interest, while safeguarding and growing sustainable agriculture, fisheries and forestry and supporting Australia's health, biosecurity, trade and long-term economic prosperity. Consistent with its vision for a more sustainable and prosperous Australia through biosecurity, production and trade, the department implements regulation using coordinated pre-border, border and post-border mechanisms, working with border, national security, health and environmental agencies. This includes active collaboration with industry, community stakeholders, First Nations people, Commonwealth, state and territory agencies, and relevant domestic and international regulatory bodies.

Regulatory reform and productivity agenda

The department strongly supports the Australian Government's regulatory reform and productivity agenda and recognises that effective, fit-for-purpose regulation plays a central role in lifting productivity by safeguarding our biosecurity and food safety, enabling access to markets, ensuring our compliance with environmental and illegal logging laws, and supporting agricultural industry performance.

The department is committed to engaging industry, other regulators and whole-of-government forums to inform regulatory reform and reduce unnecessary regulatory burden, while maintaining clear accountability for regulatory decision-making. The department will deliver this by:

- reviewing and, where appropriate, adjusting its regulatory posture and risk appetite in accordance with government policy and legislative requirements, to ensure an effective balance between risk mitigation, efficiency, growth and dynamism
- identifying priority areas for regulatory reform to reduce regulatory burden and improve operational efficiency, including through streamlining regulatory processes and ensuring legislative frameworks remain appropriate to changing conditions
- supporting and contributing to cross-government initiatives to modernise regulation, including through digital transformation opportunities and the safe deployment of AI-enabled regulatory capabilities that improve responsiveness, quality and consistency.

The department is implementing a whole-of-department approach to regulatory reform, stewardship and maturity uplift, including through the establishment of a Deputy Secretary Oversight Group to provide leadership and accountability for regulatory stewardship and reform. This Group is supported by the Regulatory Practice Committee (comprising the First Assistant Secretaries for the department's regulatory systems) to set priorities and oversee delivery of a coordinated work program.

In its response to the Treasurer and Minister for Finance's 4 July 2025 post-Productivity Roundtable letter, the department proposed several regulatory reform initiatives to support the delivery of the Government's regulatory reform agenda across the department's regulatory functions. These reforms are progressed, tracked and reported through established regulatory governance arrangements, including by the Deputy Secretary Oversight Group, to ensure alignment with whole-of-government objectives and ministerial expectations.

Regulatory Policy, Practice and Performance Framework principles

The department will align its regulatory approach with the Australian Government's *Regulatory Policy, Practice and Performance Framework*, and apply the framework's six principles across the design, implementation, management and evaluation of regulation. In doing so, the department will ensure regulatory decisions are lawful, evidence-based and transparent, and reflecting its operating environment, continue to align against industry practices and community expectations.

The department will continue to engage with domestic and international regulators, including global regulatory bodies, both as a member and as appropriate, to ensure its regulatory approaches remain contemporary and aligned with global standards.

Regulatory performance and reporting

The department will take an evidence-based approach to measuring and reporting on its regulatory performance and the impact of its regulatory activities, to support transparency, accountability and continuous improvement. This includes:

- clearly defining regulatory roles and responsibilities and managing regulatory risks in a proportionate manner
- maintaining fit-for-purpose performance measurement and reporting frameworks consistent with RMG 128
- incorporating regulator performance reporting into the department's corporate planning and annual reporting processes, as required under RMG 128, the PGPA Act 2013, and the *Public Governance, Performance and Accountability Rule 2014*, to support greater transparency, accountability and continuous improvement.

Relationship with Minister and portfolio

The department is committed to supporting and working closely with the Minister and the government to deliver our regulatory responsibilities effectively and efficiently. The department will provide timely, considered and evidence-based advice on significant regulatory issues, risks and opportunities, consistent with the government's policy priorities and objectives.

As both a policy agency and a regulator, the department will be considerate of its role in the development of regulatory policy and the implementation and operationalisation of it. The department will work collaboratively with portfolio agencies with regulatory responsibilities to support a joined-up approach, share best practice and strengthen overall regulatory system performance, while respecting the statutory independence of portfolio regulators.

The department will integrate the SOE and SOI into its Corporate Plan and Annual Report processes, and publish both statements on its website and www.transparency.gov.au, to support transparency and accountability, consistent with whole-of-government performance and reporting requirements.